



Course Syllabus

English Language Arts • Grade 4

English Language Arts — Grade 4 — Course Syllabus

Mary, Star of the Sea School · Mrs. Nicolle Bekers · SY 2026-2027

Course Description

This course focuses on developing **reading, writing, speaking, and**

listening skills. Students engage with classic and modern literature, explore

grammar and vocabulary, and practice various forms of writing. Our primary

focus is that every student develops a love for — and grade-level

understanding of — books, writing, language, and grammar.

Textbook: Core novels: *Wonder* (R.J. Palacio) · *The Tale of Despereaux*

(Kate DiCamillo) · *Inside Out and Back Again* (Thanhha Lai) · *Holes* (Louis

Sachar)

Grading Policy

30%AssessmentsOral / written tests and quizzes

25%ClassworkDaily reading & writing practice

20%Writing PortfolioPublished pieces & workshop drafts

10%Projects & Presentations

Course Outline by Quarter

Q1 — Novel 1: *Wonder* by R.J. Palacio

- Reading comprehension: character analysis, multiple perspectives, theme
- Writing: personal narrative — drafting, revising, publishing
- Grammar: nouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs; sentence structure
- Vocabulary: novel-based words + word study

Q2 — Novel 2: *The Tale of Despereaux* by Kate DiCamillo

- Plot structure, hero's journey, fantasy elements
- Writing: creative narrative with sensory detail & dialogue
- Grammar: pronouns, verb tenses, subject-verb agreement
- Vocabulary: precise word choice; context clues

Q3 — Novel 3: *Inside Out and Back Again* by Thanhà Lại

- Novel in verse: free-verse poetry & figurative language
- Writing: opinion & argument with reasons and evidence
- Grammar: possessives, commas, quotations
- Vocabulary: Greek & Latin roots; shades of meaning

Q4 — Novel 4: *Holes* by Louis Sachar

- Interwoven plots, cause and effect, symbolism
- Writing: informative / explanatory research report
- Grammar: comparative & superlative; prefixes & suffixes
- Vocabulary: multiple-meaning words; dictionary skills

Required Materials

Daily:

- ---

 - Composition or spiral notebook (Reader's / Writer's Notebook)
- ---

 - Erasable pen, pencil, eraser and highlighter
- ---

 - Sticky notes for annotating novels
- ---

 - School-issued iPad (with Google Classroom access)
- ---

 - School planner

Supplemental Textbook: Core novels: *Wonder* (R.J. Palacio) · *The Tale of*

Despereaux (Kate DiCamillo) · *Inside Out and Back Again* (Thanh Hà Lại) ·

Holes (Louis Sachar)

Homework Policy

Per school policy, students are expected to allocate up to **40 minutes of**

homework per night. The 4th grade teachers coordinate to balance

homework across subjects. Students record assignments in their planner and

check Google Classroom for reminders. Parents are expected to check

planners daily and support time management.

Late work is accepted, but submitting on time is important for developing

responsibility. Late submissions may affect the participation grade.

Classroom Expectations

- ---

 - Come to class prepared and ready to learn each day.

- ---

 - Complete homework on time; communicate in advance if circumstances

prevent completion.

- ---

 - Participate by asking questions, contributing ideas, and seeking

clarification.

- ---

 - Treat ourselves, one another, and school property with respect and

responsibility.

Important Dates (SY 2026-2027)

-
- **Parent Orientation Night:** August 12, 2026

-
- **Parent-Teacher Conferences:** Fall — Sept. 10–11, 2026 · Spring —

Feb. 19, 2027 (optional)

-
- **Expeditions:** Q1 Coconut Island (10/2), Q2 Pearl Harbor (11/16

pending) & Ice Palace (12/14), Q3 'Iolani Palace (3/5), Q4 Sherwood

Forest (6/1)

-
- **School Spelling Bee:** Nov. 20, 2026

-
- **Christmas Performance:** Dec. 18, 2026

-
- **End-of-Year Awards:** June 3, 2027

**All expeditions are subject to change.*

Academic Integrity

Teachers will structure testing to alleviate the possibility of cheating, specify

allowed collaboration, and teach the difference between summarizing and copying.

Students avoid situations that contribute to cheating or plagiarizing, avoid unauthorized assistance, and use sources as directed.

Absences & Tardiness

Students may stay home for illness, accident, quarantine, or a death in the family. For extended absences, families notify the teacher so a make-up plan can be arranged. Students are tardy after the 7:45 a.m. bell.

Food & Drink

Food is prohibited unless specified by the teacher. Only sealed water bottles allowed. Sharing food is not permitted (dietary restrictions).

Technology

Cell phones and smart watches must be off and in backpacks during the

school day. 1st offense = warning; 2nd = phone to office; 3rd = parent

notified.

Teacher Contact

Nicolle Bekers, M.A. — Intermediate Team Faculty

✉ nbekers@starofthesea.org (please allow up to 24 hours for a response on

school days)

✉ 4th Grade Team: 4thgradeteachers@starofthesea.org

✉ Office phone: 808-734-0208

✉ Office hours: 2:45–3:15 p.m. (M-F) in Room B23

Beehively Gradebook

Parents access the electronic gradebook via **Beehively**. Beehively is the

primary source for monitoring grades, missing assignments, and academic

progress throughout the school year.

